

Dschubba
2,400 Suns

Shaula
6,000 Suns

Antares
9,450 Suns

SCORPIUS

THE SCORPION

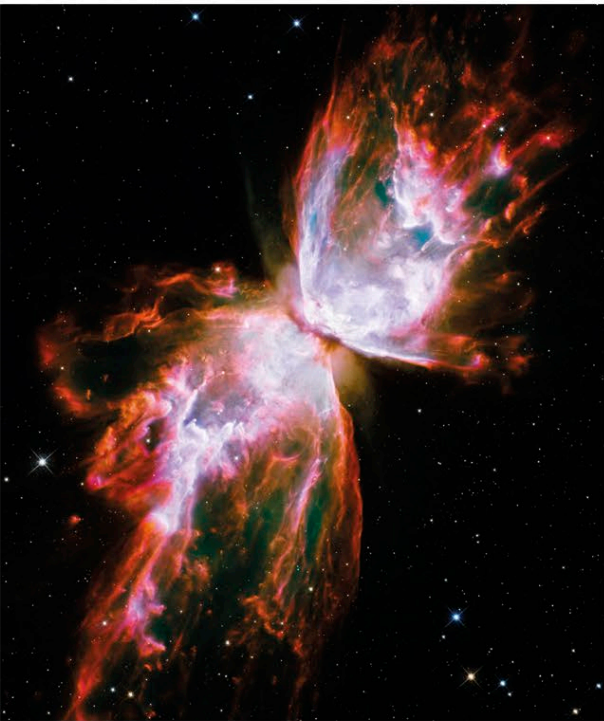
A PROMINENT CONSTELLATION OF THE ZODIAC SOUTH OF THE CELESTIAL EQUATOR, SCORPIUS IS IDENTIFIED BY ITS DISTINCTIVE HOOK SHAPE, WHICH MARKS THE SCORPION'S TAIL. RICH MILKY WAY STAR FIELDS LIE HERE, TOWARD THE CENTER OF OUR GALAXY.

Scorpius represents the scorpion that stung Orion the Hunter to death. Myth tells how the adversaries were placed on opposite sides of the sky so that as the scorpion rises, Orion sets. The constellation was once also called Scorpio, but astronomers no longer use this name.

Scorpius's brightest star, the red supergiant Antares, marks the scorpion's heart. An arc of stars leading south from Antares gives the impression of

a scorpion's tail. At the tail's end is the constellation's second-brightest star, Shaula (from the Arabic for "stinger"). The tail, situated in a dense area toward the Milky Way's center, is dotted with star clusters.

Many of the brightest stars in Scorpius and its adjoining constellations lie about 500 light-years away. They are all members of an area of recent star formation called the Scorpius–Centaurus Association. Antares is its brightest member.



◁ **NGC 6302**
NGC 6302, known as the Bug Nebula or Butterfly Nebula, is a complex planetary nebula. Gas flows away from the central star in two directions, forming the “wings” seen in this image from the Hubble Space Telescope.

△ **M80**
Bright red giants are identifiable by their color in this Hubble image of the dense globular cluster M80, around 28,000 light-years away. Red giants are stars like the Sun that are nearing the ends of their lives.

KEY DATA

Size ranking	33
Brightest stars	Antares (α) 0.9, Shaula (λ) 1.6
Genitive	Scorpii
Abbreviation	Sco
Highest in sky at 10pm	June–July
Fully visible	44°N–90°S

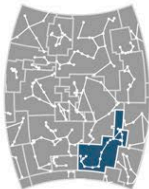


CHART 4

MAIN STARS

Antares Alpha (α) Scorpii Variable red supergiant	0.9	↔	550 light-years
Graffias Beta (β) Scorpii Blue-white main sequence star	2.6	↔	400 light-years
Dschubba Delta (δ) Scorpii Blue-white subgiant	2.3	↔	500 light-years
Epsilon (ε) Scorpii Orange giant	2.3	↔	64 light-years
Theta (θ) Scorpii White giant	1.9	↔	300 light-years
Shaula Lambda (λ) Scorpii Blue-white subgiant	1.6	↔	570 light-years
Lesath Upsilon (υ) Scorpii Blue-white subgiant	2.7	↔	580 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

M4 Globular cluster
M6 (Butterfly Cluster) Open cluster
M7 Open cluster
M80 Globular cluster
NGC 6302 (Bug Nebula) Planetary nebula, also known as the Butterfly Nebula

▷ **Star distances**
The nearest of Scorpius's main pattern stars is Epsilon (ε) Scorpii, at 64 light-years away. The most distant is Zeta¹ (ζ¹) Scorpii, at about 2,570 light-years from Earth. (The other member of the double star Zeta Scorpii, Zeta², is only about 130 light-years away.) Many of the stars in Scorpius are members of the Scorpius–Centaurus Association (a group of young stars formed at about the same time) and are at similar distances from Earth: about 500 light-years away.

